

Spain's far right eyes a 'great revolution'

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POLITICO's must-read briefing on what's driving the day in Brussels, by Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur and Gabriel Gavin. By MAX GRIERA BUENOS DÍAS

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BUENOS DÍAS! This is politics reporter Max Grier, writing from my home country's sweltering capital for Day 3 of our Playbook road trip ... eating tortilla de patatas and drinking tinto de verano. Tomorrow we head east to Bratislava.

In today's Playbook:

- Spain's far right maps out a plan to shake up politics in Madrid and Brussels.
- Why Pedro Sánchez's election prospects look dire ... and what the PSOE can do about it.

Faces in the crowd: Rebeca Torró, Manon Aubry, Tom Berendsen, Lluís Areny, Rosa Martínez, Ed Miliband, Mette Frederiksen, Raphaël Glucksmann, Verónica Martínez, Alexander Dobrindt, Clémence Robin, Miguel de Cervantes, Mykhailo Fedorov, Christine Lagarde and more.

DRIVING THE DAY

SEIZE THE MOMENT: Spain's far-right Vox sees a string of elections across Europe as a chance for nationalist parties to take power in some of the EU's biggest countries and use their combined muscle to force Brussels to the right, senior party figure Jorge Buxadé told Playbook.

Road to power: Spain is due to vote by August 2027, four years after an inconclusive election returned Socialist Pedro Sánchez to power at the head of a minority coalition with left-wing Sumar. After a string of scandals and setbacks for Sánchez (more on that below), polls point to an electoral majority for the center-right People's Party (PP) and Vox.

France, Poland and Italy are also heading to national elections over the next 18 months, with far-right or nationalist parties strongly placed in each.

"For the first time in history, there is a possibility that all four nations could have conservative and patriotic governments," said Buxadé, who leads Vox's delegation in the European Parliament. "And that would, of course, be the great revolution."

The game plan: In Spain, Buxadé said Vox would push for mass deportations and “remigration,” a sweeping deregulation drive and “national priority” for Spaniards in allocating housing, welfare and benefits. Vox would pursue these objectives whether the party entered government with the PP or supported a minority administration.

And in Brussels ... a Vox-backed government would take a harder line in the European Council, with Buxadé saying Spain should be prepared to use national vetoes and stop automatically accommodating EU initiatives.

No more yes men: “We won’t be a government that goes to Brussels to beg or say yes to everything [European Commission President Ursula] von der Leyen puts forward,” he said, arguing that having more ideological friends in national governments would give the far right greater power to sway the EU agenda.

The numbers: PP is leading the Spanish polls with 33 percent, with Vox on 17 percent, according to POLITICO’s Poll of Polls , which would comfortably grant a combination of the two enough seats for a parliamentary majority. Sánchez’s center-left PSOE currently sits at 26 percent.

The numbers — continued: The broader picture is similarly favorable to the nationalist right in other parts of the EU, with the National Rally on course to win France’s April presidential election, Poland’s hard-right contesting Donald Tusk’s premiership and Giorgia Meloni’s Brothers of Italy still the leading force in Rome.

Riding the same wave: Vox’s priorities overlap closely with many of those parties’ strongest themes, especially on migration, resistance to parts of the Green Deal, farming rules and the argument that national governments should reclaim more room to maneuver from Brussels.

Trial run: Regional deals between the PP and Vox offer a glimpse of how the far-right party could influence the center-right’s more moderate agenda, including moves to deport unaccompanied migrant minors, ban burqas and niqabs in public spaces, ax environmental taxes and defend intensive livestock farming, while opposing Mercosur, EU fishing limits and the Green Deal. PP declined to comment.

Pushback: “The People’s Party and Vox, although they have different acronyms, are exactly the same,” PSOE organization secretary Rebeca Torró told Playbook, attacking their hardline migration plans while crediting Sánchez’s migration and economic policies with driving growth and making Spain “a European reference.”

Bottom line: A bigger far-right presence in government would be a stress test for Europe’s mainstream parties — and show how far nationalist demands on migration, the Green Deal and national powers can pull the EU agenda their way.

BIG AND BREAKING

FEDOROV DEMANDS WARTIME ELECTIONS: Ukraine’s ousted defense chief Mykhailo Fedorov called for the country to go to the polls in a bombshell video address last night — the most significant domestic political challenge to Volodymyr Zelenskyy since Russia’s full-scale invasion.

TRUMP HITS PAUSE: Donald Trump said on Truth Social overnight he’s delaying a 50 percent tariff on some Canadian goods that was set to go into effect today, after the U.S. and Canada reached a preliminary deal.

DUTCH DEFENSE: The Netherlands' Foreign Minister Tom Berendsen has slammed the Trump administration's decision to sanction two senior International Criminal Court officials as part of its campaign against the tribunal.

CASH-STRAPPED AND UNDERSTAFFED: U.K. Foreign Secretary Ed Miliband has pledged to put climate and international aid at the heart of a new-look British foreign policy — but his department is short of the money and people he needs to pull it off, Charlie Cooper and Esther Webber write.

PSOE'S CHESS BOARD

SÁNCHEZ'S COALITION PROBLEM: The Spanish prime minister's route to another term is getting narrower as an alliance of left-wing parties, along with Catalan and Basque nationalists, locks Sánchez into power fractures. It's a new obstacle for a leader who survived grim polling in 2023 by stitching those parties together.

On his left: Sánchez's left-wing partners have splintered, though Sumar co-chiefs Verónica Martínez and Rosa Martínez told Playbook they expect the left to reunite: "There is no scenario in which a broad alliance won't contest the next election."

And in Catalonia ... the rise of the hardline separatist Catalan Alliance to the top of polls is pushing established nationalist parties in the autonomous community to harden their stance toward Madrid, threatening another source of support for Sánchez. As for the Catalan Alliance itself, it will sit out the Spanish election, with communications secretary Lluís Areny telling Playbook the party has "no business in the parliament of the country that occupies us."

More trouble: Sánchez's PSOE is also reeling from an alleged public-contract kickback scheme that has ensnared a former transport minister and the predecessor of Torró, who was brought in to help clean things up.

Rotten apples: Torró said a forensic audit found PSOE's finances fully traceable and described the wrongdoing as isolated: "We may have had rotten apples, but we removed them."

The Sánchez bet: PSOE hopes strong growth, record employment and fear of a PP-Vox government can recreate its 2023 comeback. "Until the last two or three days, the polls didn't say we would govern again," Torró said, adding surveys are only snapshots and the electoral campaign will trigger "real mobilization."

Not even Vox would rule out an unexpected Sánchez victory. "You shouldn't take anything for granted, especially with Sánchez," Buxadé told Playbook.

****Can Europe still win on the decisive issues? Join the debate on "How Europe Wins" and engage with leading voices from politics, science, business, and culture at the European Forum Alpbach from 24 August to 4 September. Secure your ticket now !****

5 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

CLIMATE CHANGE HITS OCEANS: Europe's seas are overheating and climate change is to blame , researchers warned in a study published today, Zia Weise writes.

SOCIALIST INFIGHTING: Spanish and Italian social democrats have sent a letter to the Party of European Socialists' leadership complaining about Danish center-left Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen aligning with Italy's Meloni on migration, ANSA reports .

FANGS FOR THE MEMORIES: After French MEP Manon Aubry revealed she was bitten by a viper, Paul Dallison looks at other times politicians have been attacked by animals .

TEEN-ACCOUNT ROLLOUT: OpenAI is gradually rolling out a new default experience for minors in ChatGPT. More in our Morning Tech for Pros.

KEEP IT LOCAL: An EU industrial-policy bill would give European companies an edge in government contracts, but the message from voters in most member nations is that their leaders should spend money on products made in their own country , writes Aude van den Hove.

MADRID CORNER

BEST ROOFTOP: If you're unlucky enough to be braving Madrid's burning streets in the early afternoon, duck into the cultural center Círculo de Bellas Artes for some respite from the heat.

You can take shelter in the free government-funded (and air-conditioned) "climate refuge," with activities and desks (even mattresses laid out across the building's beautiful ballroom). Or, if you can spare €6 for entry and at least a tenner for a drink, head up to the rooftop bar for sweeping 360-degree views of Madrid.

Excursion: One of Madrid's best-kept secrets is just a 30-minute train ride from the capital. Alcalá de Henares, a historic city with roots stretching back to Roman times, is the birthplace of "Don Quixote" author Miguel de Cervantes — you can visit his reconstructed childhood home — and home to one of Spain's oldest universities. Make sure to get deliberately lost in the ancient center.

For lunch ... you can head to Hemisferio Café, where with each drink you also will get a mini-sandwich of your choice.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Cloudy with a chance of rain. High of 21C.

WORLD CUP ON YOUR DOORSTEP: Belgium's hockey teams are fighting to stay in the World Cup in Wavre, with the men's Red Lions needing a win against Malaysia today and the women's Red Panthers facing Ireland tomorrow. Tickets are still available.

CATCHING THE OMNIBUS: Simplification has reached the non-bubble parts of Brussels — and this time we're talking actual buses. STIB is speeding up student season ticket applications, promising to validate eligible school certificates submitted online within one working day. Bruzz has more.

NIGHT TRAIN NIGHTMARE: Agriculture Commissioner Christophe Hansen's comms aide Clémence Robin racked up more than 5 million views on X after recounting how a Brussels-to-Vienna sleeper trip with her son ended in a shared seating carriage.

Still on board: Robin told Playbook she remains "a strong supporter of rail," though she'll "certainly think twice before taking a night train again." Operator ÖBB, she added, was "extremely understanding and

helpful”... once she reached Vienna.

YOUR MOVE: Muntpunt’s weekly chess meet-up runs today from 4 p.m. to 7 p.m. in central Brussels, with all levels of players welcome.

Playbook came to Brussels in 2015 and changed how this town starts its day. It has now landed in Canberra: a capital with just as many officials and, until now, no daily briefing of its own. Canberra Playbook: free, daily, radically impartial. Subscribe free .

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Interior Minister Alexander Dobrindt has emerged as the coalition’s fixer on everything from drone threats to dealmaking, putting him in the frame for a bigger job.

Paris: Center-left MEP Raphaël Glucksmann will officially launch his presidential bid on Sunday.

London: Andy Burnham is heading north in his campaign to end rough sleeping , one of his boldest promises since entering No. 10.

Washington: Donald Trump’s penchant for scrambling the global order remains unchanged ... with no apparent off-ramp from the costly war in Iran.

Canberra: Far-right party One Nation is setting the terms for Australia’s next round of polarizing debates.

AGENDA

— ECB President Christine Lagarde participates in the World Economic Forum’s International Business Council panel “Global Economic Outlook” in Geneva at 9:15.

BIRTHDAYS

Former MEPs Daniela Rondinelli, Javier Nart and Stephen Hughes; former MEP Bernd Lucke; French politician Jean-Luc Mélenchon; BusinessEurope’s Markus Beyrer; Austrian journalist and POLITICO 28 alum Armin Wolf; former U.S. President Bill Clinton turns 80. It’s World Humanitarian Day.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO’s EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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